

# CASE STUDY

*Elle & Vire*

Brand Management  
Date: 2 June, 2026

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# THE NORMANDY PREMIUM

An 80-year promise of *L'Envie du Vrai*

Founded in 1945, Condé-sur-Vire, Normandy,  
**Elle&Vire** is the **#1 cream brand (#3 in butter)** in France,  
and **Top 10 most loved food brands**



**120+**

Countries  
Exported (#1)

**88.5%, 44%**

Avg. Aided - Spontaneous  
Brand Awareness

*Elle&Vire* is also the main partner of the **Coupe du Monde de la Pâtisserie 2025**  
and **Bocuse d'Or partner for 20+ years**



# BRAND IDENTITY

Modern, Authentic & With a Simple, Beautiful Story

Elle & Vire



## External Facets

### [Physique]

Iconic **Red & White signature** packaging with **stripes/checks pattern**, **Condé-sur-Vire** origin stamp

### [Relationship]

Trusted culinary users including **70%** of French households & **65%** of starred chefs

### [Reflected Image]

**The Discerning Cook:** quality-conscious, shops in high-end supermarkets, won't compromise

## Internal Facets

### [Personality]

Warm, Expert & Trustworthy, modern yet traditional;  
*"my grandmother's thick fresh cream"*

### [Culture]

**Norman Gastronomic DNA:** French terroir, cooperative heritage since 1945, birthplace of cream

### [Self-Concept]

*"I Cook with the Best", "It's a noble product. There's no substitute for cream."*

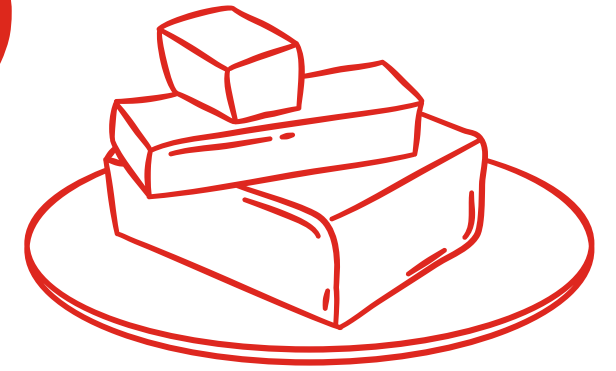


# THE THREE CORE VALUES

The unique 'recipe' no competitor can replicate

*"Modern, authentic, with a simple, beautiful story" — Gilles de Galard*

*"When I hear Elle & Vire, I think about... Normandy, nature, the French terroir, quality." — Consumer*



## AUTHENTICITY & NATURAL ORIGIN



Rooted in Condé-sur-Vire since 1945, the brand's Norman origin is not a marketing add-on but its founding DNA. Consumers spontaneously associate it with **terroir, nature, and genuine French quality.**

## CULINARY EXCELLENCE



Proven by 65% of starred chefs using Excellence cream, **Pierre Gagnaire** ambassador since 2005, **Bocuse d'Or partner** 20+ years, and **Maison de la Crème** founded in 2014.

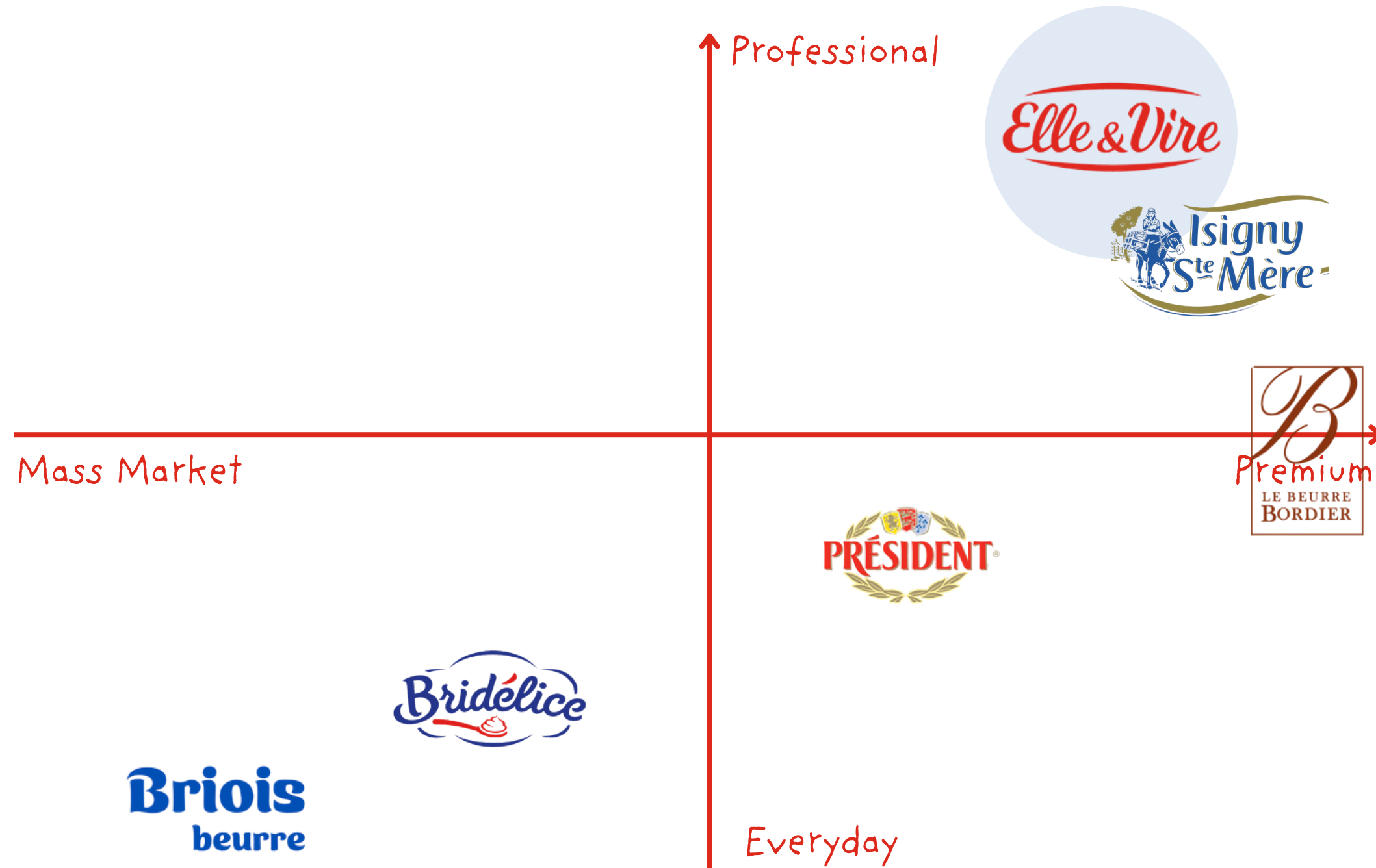
## INNOVATION



Every major product launch traces back to an observed consumer need. Innovation at Elle & Vire is not trend-chasing but a disciplined commitment to **making authentic quality more accessible and practical.**



# POSITIONING MAP



**Elle & Vire owns the only defensible position in the top-right quadrant**

Competitors either lack premium credentials (Bridélice, MDD, Briois) or lack professional scale (Bordier, Isigny).

**65% of starred chefs choosing E&V** is the proof point that makes this position sticky and hard to replicate.

# POP AND POD

Elle&Vire's Point of Parity V.S. Point of Difference



## Point of Parity, POP

- **Dairy quality cues:** smoothness, freshness, taste (also claimed by Bridélice, Isigny)
- **Normandy / pastoral terroir imagery** (shared with Isigny, Paysan Breton, Président)
- **Full dairy product range:** cream, butter, yogurts, cooking aids
- **Modern sustainability credentials:** recyclable caps, anti-waste, biodiversity

## Point of Difference, POD

- **Chef credibility:** 65% of starred chefs use Excellence; Gagnaire, Michalak, Bocuse d'Or, MOF, Maison de la Crème
- **"L'envie du vrai" / Condé-sur-Vire authenticity:** village + the two rivers literally in the brand name
- **Innovation firsts + meeting needs:** 1st French UHT milk (1970), 1st UHT cream (1975), 1st soft-from-fridge butter (1992)
- **#1 in the French cream market** – "la référence" (gold standard) for chefs and consumers alike

# STRATEGY PROPOSAL

New concerns shape french dairy consumption and trends



1

## Protect the Core Masterbrand

- Keep all cow-milk dairy products under the Elle & Vire masterbrand.
- Reinforce the brand's key associations: Normandy origin, natural quality, and culinary excellence.
- Simplify pack communication to make product type, usage, and fat content easier to understand at shelf.

2

## Expand Without Dilution

- Launch La Crème de la Terre as a separate plant-based brand.
- Use a house-of-brands approach to avoid weakening Elle & Vire's dairy terroir identity.
- Target younger, eco-conscious, and alternative-diet consumers through a distinct proposition.

3

## Leverage Credible Extension

- Launch Elle & Vire L'Atelier Givré as a premium frozen dessert line.
- Use a source-brand architecture so the extension benefits from Elle & Vire's cream expertise.
- Build on the brand's legitimacy in indulgence, craftsmanship, and chef-quality dairy.

# STRATEGIC LOGIC & BRAND FIT



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## Strategic Logic

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- Elle & Vire continues to own the premium-professional dairy space through its masterbrand, where Normandy heritage and chef endorsement give strong legitimacy.
- Growth comes from adjacent categories with different branding roles, not from stretching one brand across incompatible meanings.
- The strategy therefore combines a Branded House for core cow-dairy, a separate brand for plant-based, and a source-brand extension for premium frozen desserts.

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## Why this fits the positioning

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- Elle & Vire stands for Authenticity & Natural Origin, Culinary Excellence, and selective Innovation.
- Using the same name for plant-based would conflict with its identity as a sacred dairy icon of French terroir.
- A premium dessert extension remains credible because it builds on the brand's established expertise in cream and indulgence.

3

## Expected Brand Effect

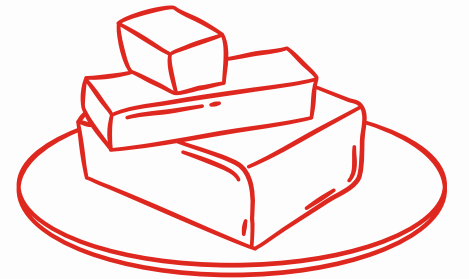
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- Protect core equity by keeping the masterbrand focused and coherent.
- Capture new demand via a separate plant-based proposition.
- Stretch credibly into high-value desserts through source-brand endorsement.
- Maintain consistency between positioning, architecture, and innovation choices.



# A SHIFTING LANDSCAPE FOR FRENCH CONSUMERS

New concerns shape french dairy consumption and trends



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## THE SEARCH FOR ALTERNATIVES TO CONVENTIONAL DAIRY

French consumers are increasingly questioning standard cow's milk products, driven by health, digestibility, and environmental concerns. This takes multiple forms: a surge in **plant-based alternatives** (oat, soy, almond), with the French dairy alternatives market projected to reach **\$889 million by 2033** (10.5% CAGR); and a strong appetite for **alternative animal milks**, particularly goat and sheep products, which are growing rapidly especially among younger consumers seeking more natural and digestible options. *Grand View Research, 2025*

2

## VALUE FOR MONEY PRESSURE

Despite easing inflation, **French consumers remain price-conscious**, making value for money a growing decision factor even in premium categories like cream and butter. This pressure is particularly strong among **younger consumers**.

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## SUSTAINABILITY EXPECTATIONS

Environmental concern is now one of the **top issue for European consumers**. Dairy brands are increasingly expected to demonstrate **responsible sourcing**, **reduced carbon footprint**, and **ethical farming practices**, or risk losing relevance.

# STRENGTHS – ELLE&VIRE AND ITS CONSUMERS



## 1) A Strong and Authentic Brand Image

Consumer interviews reveal a deeply rooted **emotional connection to the brand**. Elle & Vire is consistently associated with **quality**, and **Normandy heritage**; values that resonate strongly with today's naturalness trend. This nostalgic, terroir-based identity is a genuine asset in a market where **authenticity is increasingly valued**. → "For me, Elle & Vire is my grandmother's thick fresh cream, so it guarantees quality."

## 2) A Loyal and Frequent Consumer Base

**70% of French households** consume at least one Elle & Vire product during the year, and interview data confirms that many consumers buy cream on a **weekly basis**. This level of penetration and loyalty is a **strong commercial foundation** that competitors struggle to match.

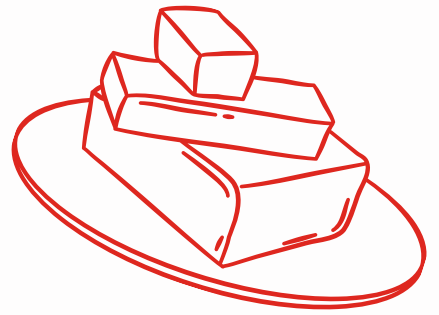
## 3) A Credible Premium Positioning

With **aided brand awareness of 88%** for cream and 89% for butter, Elle & Vire enjoys exceptional visibility. Its association with renowned chefs like **Pierre Gagnaire** and its presence in prestigious competitions like Le Bocuse d'Or reinforces its premium credentials, particularly relevant as consumers increasingly seek **trusted, high-quality** brands for home cooking.

## 4) A Natural Fit With the Homemade Cooking Trend

Consumer interviews confirm that cream is primarily used as a **cooking ingredient** (quiches, pasta, sauces). As more consumers embrace home cooking and seek **quality ingredients**, Elle & Vire's positioning as the go-to cream for serious cooking becomes a clear strength.

# VULNERABILITIES – ELLE&VIRE AND IT'S CONSUMERS



## 1) Price sensitivity

Consumer interviews clearly **flag price as a friction point** → "Elle & Vire products are more expensive than their competitors."

In a context where value for money is an increasingly important decision factor, particularly among younger consumers, this premium pricing risks **alienating a growing segment** of the market. The Kantar study also confirms that Elle & Vire shoppers tend to concentrate in high-end supermarkets, suggesting **limited reach beyond already loyal**, affluent consumers.

## 2) No Answer to the Alternative Dairy Trend

Elle & Vire's portfolio remains **entirely anchored in conventional cow's milk dairy**. The brand currently has no plant-based or alternative milk offer, leaving it exposed as **consumer preferences diversify**, especially among younger generations.

## 3) Packaging Complexity Creating Shelf Confusion

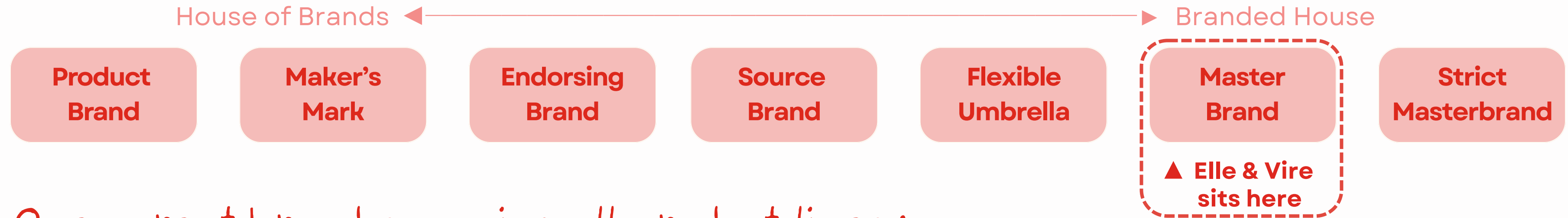


The Kantar study indicates that **packaging is not communicating clearly enough** at the point of purchase, a **critical moment in the consumer decision journey**. → "Consumers hesitate for several seconds to a minute in front of the refrigerated shelf, comparing prices, expiry dates, ingredients, qualities and specificities"

## 4) A Weak Connection With Younger Consumers

The brand's emotional equity is strongly built on nostalgia and tradition which, while powerful among older loyal consumers, may struggle to **resonate with younger generations**. Combined with price sensitivity Elle & Vire risks a slow **erosion of its future consumer base**.

# ELLE & VIRE'S BRAND ARCHITECTURE



*One parent brand spanning all product lines :*

## SINGLE BRAND IDENTITY

All products – cream, butter, yogurt, desserts, food service – carry the Elle & Vire name and Eiffel Tower logo. No separate sub-brand names in France.

## MASTERBRAND EQUITY TRANSFER

Products leverage 88% aided awareness and Normandy heritage. France is the #1 EU butter consumer at 8 kg/person/year – the masterbrand spans this high-consumption market (CNIEL, 2024).

## TWO CHANNELS, ONE BRAND

Retail (B2C) and Food Service (B2B) both use Elle & Vire. The 'Excellence' cream line for chefs is a product descriptor, not a separate brand.



# BRAND PORTFOLIO & HIERARCHY

\*Elle & Vire uses product descriptors (e.g. 'Excellence', 'Beurre Tendre') within the masterbrand, not independent sub-brands. This is a Branded House / Masterbrand architecture



# PROS, CONS & STRATEGIC VERDICT

## Advantages

### EQUITY TRANSFER

88% aided awareness transfers to every new product launch, reducing marketing spend. The French dairy market is worth €25bn+ annually – one trusted name covers it all (CNIEL, 2024).

### ECONOMIES OF SCALE

Shared media budget and packaging across 134,000 tons of product yearly. France leads EU butter consumption at 8 kg/person/year, justifying a unified brand investment (CNIEL, 2024).

### GLOBAL COHERENCE

A single brand in 118 countries avoids confusion. International chefs recognise one name, making the food-service strategy viable.

### NORMANDY HALO

Geographic identity amplifies all products simultaneously. One heritage story powers cream, butter, yogurt and dessert lines alike.

## Vulnerabilities

### NEGATIVE SPILLOVER RISK

A product recall or food scandal hits the entire portfolio at once – cream, butter, yogurt and Food Service all exposed simultaneously.

### PRIVATE LABEL PRESSURE

MDD (private label) cream holds significant French market share and is growing. The same masterbrand must defend premium positioning against cheaper alternatives (CNIEL, 2024).

### MARKET STRETCH CONSTRAINTS

Plant-based dairy alternatives are the fastest-growing segment in France. Entering this category risks stretching the Normandy-cow heritage brand beyond its credibility.

### LOW SPONTANEOUS RECALL

Only 42–46% spontaneous awareness despite 88–89% aided – the masterbrand does not dominate mental availability vs. private labels in everyday shopping.

**VERDICT:** The masterbrand works well for core dairy — but private label growth and plant-based trends challenge its stretch.



# EXTENSION 1: PLANT-BASED DAIRY

## LA CRÈME DE LA TERRE



### THE CONCEPT

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Premium plant-based cream made from french-sourced ingredients.  
Engineered for professional use: thickness, binding, and whipping

### STRATEGIC RATIONALE

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Capitalizes on the shift towards plant-based nutrition. Unlocks a new target (younger, eco-conscious consumers) traditional dairy products can't reach  
*The Good Food Institute, 2025*

### DILEMMA

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Elle & Vire is a sacred dairy icon of the French terroir. Forcing it into the plant-based market directly introduces brand dilution risk

# BRAND ARCHITECTURE: HOUSE OF BRANDS

## PRODUCT BRAND (INDIVIDUAL NAME)

La Crème de la Terre is launched as an entirely independent entity. The name, visual assets, and brand communications will have 0% visible association with the Elle & Vire parent brand. The consumer sees a stand alone brand.



(Master brand)



(Brand A)

### ADVANTAGES

- Has the resources of the parent company (R&D, distribution, etc.)
- Drops the risk of backlash from traditional consumers

### HURDLES

- Cannot take advantage of the “Elle et Vire” identity
- Increased cost of developing the brand from scratch



# EXTENSION 2: ICE CREAM

## ELLE & VIRE L'ATELIER GIVRÉ



### THE CONCEPT

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Premium line of slow-churned French ice creams crafted exclusively with authentic Normandy cream and iconic pastry bases

### STRATEGIC RATIONALE

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This extension captures the high-margin premium dessert sector, marking a natural evolution from Elle & Vire's existing non-frozen dessert portfolio. It directly harnesses the brand's proven technological capabilities and legendary reputation for cream mastery and fat emulsification

# BRAND ARCHITECTURE: BRANDED HOUSE

## SOURCE BRAND

L'Atelier Givré uses a Source Brand architecture within the Branded House framework. This two-level hierarchy allows the new line to inherit the masterbrand's awareness while creating a distinct, premium identity tailored specifically for the frozen category



(Parent Brand)



### ADVANTAGES

- Trust transfer: consumers associate “Elle & Vire” with quality
- Lower launch cost: the new brand does not need to be developed

### HURDLES

- Contamination risk: any failures will impact the Elle & Vire reputation

# SOURCES

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- 3 CNIEL. (2024). L'économie laitière en chiffres – Édition 2024. Centre National Interprofessionnel de l'Économie Laitière. <https://www.cniel.com/sites/default/files/2024-10/L%27économie%20laitière%20en%20chiffres%20-%20Edition%202024.pdf>
- 4 Grandviewresearch.com. (2025). France Dairy Alternatives Market Size | Industry Report, 2033. [online] Available at: <https://www.grandviewresearch.com/industry-analysis/france-dairy-alternatives-market-report>.
- 5 Elle & Vire Professionnel turns 80 and sets the pace for global gastronomy. (<https://www.hospitalitynewsmag.com/elle-vire-professionnel-turns-80-sets-global-gastronomy/>)
- 6 Aaker, D. A., & Joachimsthaler, E. (2000). The brand relationship spectrum: The key to the brand architecture challenge. California Management Review, 42(4), 8–23.

## Brand Management Case Study

# THANK YOU

